

enough without good storytelling, awareness of audience sentiment, and careful commercial planning.

The limited successes of 2025 show that the industry is actively rethinking its cost structures. It is applying stricter financial and operational discipline to filmmaking and adjusting expectations for risk and return, rather than relying on star power alone.

A PERIOD OF LEARNING

Many things made 2025 unique. For around two years, Bollywood struggled as big-budget films failed, largely on the back of an inefficient business model. High star fees left limited capital for production value, which consequently affected quality in several cases. While stars walked away unscathed, smaller producers, distributors, and exhibitors bore the brunt of the losses.

To that extent, overhauling the engine was necessary for the survival of the Hindi film industry. Akshaye Rathi, director, Aashirwad Theatres, calls 2025 a year when breakout films worked, creating renewed interest and possibilities for filmmakers. He cites the case of *Saiyaara*, with two newcomers in a romantic musical. “Then, we had *Chhaava* and *Dhurandhar*. In the case of *Mahavatar Narsimha*, there has never been an Indian animated film doing that well.”

The overarching takeaway has been to expect the unexpected. Even highly hyped films like *War 2*, *Sikandar*, *Baaghi 4* and *Mastiii 4* did not recover their budgets. An interesting hit was *Sitaare Zameen Par*, an Aamir Khan production, in which the actor plays a basketball coach. Before discussing others that made it big, a mention of *Kantara: A Legend – Chapter 1* is necessary. On a budget of ₹125 crore,

this Kannada film (it had dubbed versions in Hindi, Tamil, Telugu and Malayalam), raked in over ₹800 crore. Its producer, Chaluve Gowda, Co-founder & MD of Hombale Films, insists the success recipe is simple. “The story was actually the same. It all comes down to the way you handle it, and that must be different each time,” he says with a smile. Hombale Films has also produced *KGF: Chapter 1* and a sequel, followed by *Kantara*, *Salaar: Part 1—Ceasefire*.

Post-pandemic dynamics introduced new challenges. Staying away from the high-star-fee model during the frenzy when OTT platforms paid huge sums for content rights, leading to stars raising their fees, was not easy. “Today, the au-

dience wants a big spectacle. Having a film with big stars has failed too often,” says Deshpande. Her company consciously moved away from that construct and “will sign on a star if there is a requirement.” She emphasises how, in a very short period, Jio Studios had successes like *Laapataa Ladies* and *Singham 3*.

Upfront OTT deals helped producers recover a significant portion of their costs, often covering star salaries in big-budget films. The amount left to recover was much smaller. However, it created a risky model and left no room for the smaller producers. When films with big stars started to fail, wealthy OTT companies slowed down, which allowed for disruption. Since then, star fees have become more reasonable,



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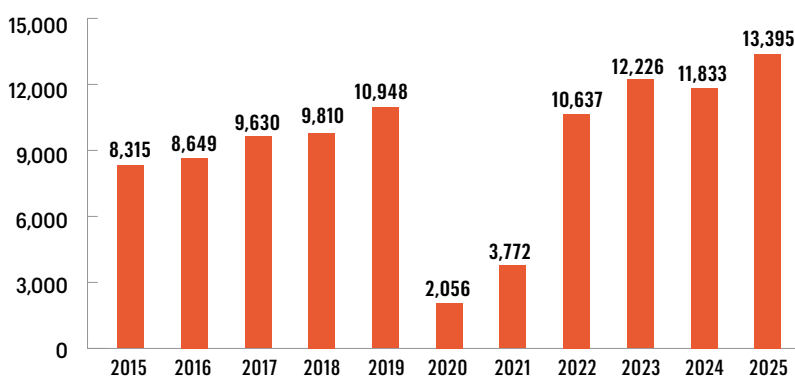


India's Box Office Collections

• Theatrical revenue has regained its importance, and only when it performs well do OTT platforms step in



GROSS COLLECTION (₹CRORE)



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